

Toward a Connective Ethnography of Online/Offline Literacy Networks

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The time for thinking about the Internet and digital literacies as revolutionary has passed. Books have been published, careers made, and computer networks installed. Now we are ready to move onto an even more difficult concept: How do we think about the everyday? Haythornthwaite and Wellman (2002) asserted the following:

Ignoring the Internet is as huge a mistake as seeing it as a savior is. It is the boringness and routineness that makes the Internet important because this means that it is being pervasively incorporated into people's lives. It is time now for more differentiated analyses of the Internet that take into account how it has increasingly become embedded into everyday life. (p. 7)

Understanding boringness and routineness of everyday Internet research is captivating and important work. One of the reasons for its importance is that research into digital literacies will, one hopes, yield richer understandings of nondigital literacies as well (Hull & Schultz, 2001). One of our current limitations in achieving this kind of cross-fertilization in theory building is to confront from the outset some of our haunting dichotomies: computer-mediated versus face-to-face, online versus offline, virtual versus real (Haythornthwaite

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& Wellman, 2002), and in the new literacy studies, in school versus out of school (Hull & Schultz, 2001).

How do we work toward building knowledge that might take Internet practices out of the exotic and assert their everydayness and their qualities of the *quotidian*? Perhaps one of the best ways to be confronted is to attempt to research these practices as lived experiences in the everyday lives of youth. This chapter addresses the digital divide of research on literacy, a divide that brackets “digital literacies” and “Internet spaces” in special conference sessions, special journals, and special handbooks such as this. I hope to work the tension between, on the one hand, asserting that digital literacy practices are fascinating, worthy of study, and in many ways unique, and on the other hand, moving toward a methodology for understanding digital literacies as flowing with and interconnected to streams of other literacy practices, material culture, traditional media, movements of people, identity practices, and the social construction of technologies.

As indexed in my use of the phrase “lived experiences,” this chapter discusses the development of an ethnographic approach for studying digital literacies as social practices. Ethnography is traditionally recognized as a practice of spending time observing and participating in a particular environment and using a range of data collection techniques to describe human practices in that environment. Baszanger & Dodier (1997, pp. 8–11), considering new developments in ethnography, offer three productively broad characteristics of the goals of ethnography. First, ethnography insists that understanding phenomena requires empirical observation. While it may appear unnecessary to state this characteristic, it is a helpful way of distinguishing ethnographic practice, as social science, from approaches in the humanities that work through deduction, introspection, philosophic inquiry, textual interpretation, and other means. Second, ethnography seeks to remain open to new data and to new codes for interpreting data. This characteristic sets ethnography apart from research methods that establish a priori codes, items to collect, and schedules for data collection. Ethnography works with “sensitizing” concepts, “suggest[ing] directions along which to look” rather than with “definitive” constructs “provid[ing] prescriptions of what to see” (Blumer, 1969, p. 148). This characteristic of openness has long conflicted with the need for methodological structure in research and even more so today given the politics of knowledge production, in some parts of the world, that increasingly favor standardized research structures and reproducibility over endogenous, contingent approaches. Third, ethnography seeks to satisfy the requirement to connect or *ground* observations and interpretations with a specific field that is limited in time and space. This characteristic is important for separating ethnography from some social science methods that dissociate data from its relevant context in order to universalize interpretations. Moreover, this traditional requirement of ethnography is particularly important for the present

discussion as the specific context of activity becomes fuzzy or tends to fracture when we follow online practices. This discussion of initial characteristics of ethnography is by necessity limited and is intended merely as a means of orientation; a richer discussion of ethnography with particular utility for research in social linguistics has been recently drafted by the Coordinating Committee of the U.K. Linguistic Ethnography Forum (2004).

My own interests and commitments to understanding social practices through ethnography have been historically shaped in two key ways. A first important influence has been the work of Bruce (1999; Bruce & Leander, 1997; Bruce & Rubin, 1993) on the “situated evaluation” of technology in use. In his empirical work and theory building, Bruce argued that the problems—and possibilities—of technologies in education are a result of the complex interaction of any technological innovation with the particulars of a social situation: “How the features of the technology interact with human needs, expectations, beliefs, prior practices, and alternative tools far outweighs the properties of the technology itself” (Bruce & Rubin, 1993, p. 215). Situated evaluation is a critique of technocentrism (Papert, 1987) and techno-myopia, pushing us to shift our focus from technical tools to the social practices through which the possibilities of such tools are realized. The reasons why technologies do not work according to the ideals of developers, or do work in radically unanticipated ways, often has little to do with the tools themselves and much more to do with the relations of technologies to what we might consider the surround. My perspectives on ethnography were also initially formed by my own ethnographic studies of everyday (nondigital) literacy practices in school settings. In this work, I became invested in understanding student interaction in routine classroom discussions and the ways in which such discussions construct student identities (e.g., Leander, 2002a). In this research, I was also interested in how literacy practices in school relate to those outside of school, which I studied indirectly by considering activities located on the “fringe” of school, such as construction projects and extended fieldtrips (Leander, 2001, 2002b). These early research experiences that complicated the relationship of the school “setting” to other social spaces, along with my earlier training that complicated the relationship of technology to the social world, continue to shape my vision—and desire—to delve into messy discussions of online ethnography.

Ethnography Moves Online: Adaptation and Connective Paradigms

Early work on computer-mediated communication and media studies tended to emphasize the uniqueness of the Internet as a site; the Internet was a place where one could shape relationships, identities, and social projects in a world apart (Mitchell, 1996) from the material world, even if the caffeinated body might suffer in supporting such a life (e.g., Markham, 1998). One of the dominant conversations concerning online research, since its inception, is

how familiar methodological tools might be transferred and adapted for the unique characteristics of online social spaces. We might call these concerns, which have been fueled by arguments for the uniqueness of the Internet, the "adaptation paradigm." This general area of work problematizes the transfer of familiar methods to the Internet and works to develop new methods. Jones (1999), for instance, cautioned that using old methodological tools for new Internet experiences can restrict and confine that experience: "The range of experience is somehow changed online, both qualitatively and quantitatively, and our explanatory abilities must change with it" (p. 9). Jones' edited collection of essays described challenges posed by the Internet for social science researchers and offered broad-ranging discussions around the adaptation of qualitative and quantitative methods.

An example of a set of problems posed by the adaptation paradigm involves participant observation. How do online settings challenge the researcher in the role of participant observer? What do the characteristics of online settings imply for the researcher attempting to conduct participant observation, when researchers are told to "do what others do, but also watch [his or] her own actions, the behavior of others, and everything [he or] she could see in this social situation" and "maintain explicit awareness of everything that is going on" (Spradley, 1980, p. 54)? How might the researcher's own participation affect his or her knowledge of the sites? In contrast to offline settings, the researcher is able to go to some online venues and not have his or her existence known. The researcher then participates as lurker. As Baym (1998) and Correll (1995) both stressed, this type of participant observation would threaten the authority that comes from exposing the emerging ethnographic analysis to the challenge of interaction. Moreover, other lurkers besides the researcher could be present. If the job of the ethnographer is to maintain explicit awareness of everything that is going on at that site, what implications does the presence of invisible lurkers have for rich reporting of events? Hine (2000) argued that lurkers become important to the group through only visible activity and acknowledgement of other group members. In this manner, the ethnographer mirrors the activity and awareness of other active newsgroup members; while lurkers may be present online, their identities are not presenced in any meaningful way.

While I want to indicate the importance of work in the adaptation paradigm for challenging familiar methods and developing new ones, in this chapter my interests are different and somewhat broader. Rather than taking up the challenges posed by the application of any particular ethnographic method to the Internet as a site for literacy research, I describe a methodological approach that assumes, as its starting point, that people routinely build connections to Internet-related practices and sites and myriad offline practices and sites. Practice travels, and so must ethnography. In fact, the distinction of online and offline is perhaps best seen as an analytic heuristic, a holding place until a more grounded means of understanding and discussing technologically medi-

ated human experiences is formulated. The online/offline, virtual world/real world, and cyberspace/physical space binaries need to be disrupted not simply because they are imperfect, fuzzy distinctions, but because they provide a priori answers to some of the most intriguing questions about Internet practices. The extent that some people may actually treat various Internet relations as a “world apart” from the rest of their lives is something that needs to be socially explained as a practical accomplishment rather than as the assumed point of departure for investigation (Miller & Slater, 2000, p. 5).

The methodological approach I describe in this chapter is neither a single approach nor a robust methodology. Rather, it might be best thought of as a stance or orientation to Internet-related research that considers connections and relations as normative social practices and Internet social spaces as complexly connected to other social spaces. I use the term *connective ethnography* for the approach, which I borrow from Hine (2000), although she preferred “virtual ethnography.” *Social spatial ethnography* or *traveling ethnography* might be other appropriate terms. Connective ethnography is informed by developments in several other fields, where notions of the research “site” are being disrupted and relations are being traced among sociocultural practices and agents. This challenge has developed in critiques of traditional anthropology (e.g., Clifford, 1992; Gupta & Ferguson, 1997; Marcus, 1995; Olwig & Hastrup, 1997), in cultural and postcolonial studies (Abu-Lughod, 1991; Appadurai, 1996; McCarthy, Giardina, Harewood, & Park, 2003), and in globalization and Internet studies (Castells, 1996; Hannerz, 1996; Skelton & Valentine, 1998). Further, empirical and theoretical work that articulates technology, discourse, and cultural geography considers how Internet-related practices construct their meanings from the interactions and transformations of multiple social spaces, including the diverse spaces of the Internet (M. Crang, P. Crang, & May, 1999; Dodge & Kitchin, 2001; Saco, 2002; Valentine, Holloway, & Bingham, 2000).

In selecting work for the following review and analysis, I have focused on studies that seek to understand the relationships and connections among activity and social spaces that are decidedly Internet related and activity and social spaces that may appear distant from the Internet. In reviewing and selecting work, I have also sought to represent multiple ways in which such connections are conceived: while some studies concern the relations between the Internet and traditional media, others follow literacy practices in and out of school, while still others are concerned with tracing how student identities move across space-time. I have focused on ethnographic and interpretive work over quantitative analyses based on survey research, interview research, or other methods, although I realize that such work could be used to make claims about connections between online and offline practices. Finally, I have favored relatively detailed discussions of the relationships conceived and enacted within several key studies, rather than describing a broader range of work and abstracting principles or traversing themes.

The movement of the chapter is from slightly earlier key studies (to around the year 2000) to newer work that is underway or only beginning to appear in print. My own method has been to draw from the literature to review earlier studies and largely from interviews with researchers to review recent and ongoing work. Following a discussion of several connective ethnographic projects, the chapter closes with commentary on future directions for continuing to build connective ethnographic methodology in literacy research.

Early Connective Ethnographies of Internet Practices

The notion of building relations between offline bodies and Internet practices is nearly as old as the popular use of the Internet itself. An early example of this approach is the psychological work of Turkle (1995). Turkle contrasted the real and virtual lives of people who regularly use multiuser domains (MUDs), or virtual worlds that permit participants to interact with text-based objects and spaces. Turkle's methodology was based upon an insistence of observing her key informants face-to-face. She documented multiple relations: MUD enthusiasts seeking emotional support either act out problems from their offline lives or seek to escape from their offline lives. Ironically, for those who seek to escape emotionally, Turkle found that the MUDs often deepen offline anxiety. Other early work that largely built upon traditional ethnographic practices as they were applied to the Internet includes studies by Baym (1995a, 1995b), Correll (1995), and Paccagnella (1997). In these studies, online discussions, as they developed in real time over longer periods, were combined with face-to-face and electronic interviewing, posing of questions to the discussion group, two-way interactions, and other means of triangulating data to get a deeper sense of how communities became meaningful to the participants. While these and other early studies used offline data to support interpretations of online personal or community development, however, they tended to overemphasize the distinctions between online and offline social life (Hine, 2000, p. 27). Offline interpretations were used to build cases for online analysis—the online world or practice was still bracketed at the center of the project.

Building upon this earlier work, the following studies begin to more deliberately and self-consciously develop methodologies and findings that traverse offline and online social life in new ways. The following is a selective and not exclusive discussion of important methodological and empirical connective ethnographies of the Internet (see also Bennett, 2004; Kendall, 1999; Mann & Stewart, 2002; Sade-Beck, 2004). I have drawn from studies taking different forms, including two book-length treatments in the first cases and research articles in the others.

Daniel Miller and Don Slater

The Internet: An Ethnographic Approach reports on Daniel Miller and Don Slater's (2000) study of uses of the Internet and meanings of Internet culture

embedded in Trinidad as a place and related to the Trinidadian Diaspora. One the key conclusions of the study is that Trinidadians have a seeming natural affinity for the Internet in its various manifestations. Miller and Slater did not assume a separation of the Internet from other aspects of daily life, and they argued to the contrary that, in Trinidad, there were very few places where commerce or e-commerce, chat on playgrounds or in ICQ, or religious instruction as carried out face-to-face or by e-mail were treated in terms of clear distinctions between the “real” and the “virtual” (p. 6). While some relationships, forms of commerce, and other activities may exist uniquely online, the key issue is that participants weave these social spaces and relations into their lives in such a way that the online is experienced as real and as common place and that transitions between online and offline social spaces and identities may be less marked than researchers assume.

Miller and Slater (2000) called their approach “comparative ethnography” (p. 9), and part of the key to understanding their methodology is to consider their own scholarly histories. Miller studied culture in Trinidad for over a decade, including work on business, consumption, kinship, and identity. In contrast, Slater’s expertise was online environments and practices and especially forms of chat. The comparative ethnography proceeded by considering Miller’s funds of knowledge of Trinidadian culture in relation to the examination of Internet culture and practice, guided by Slater. For example, the pair posited that in Trinidad, the Internet is associated with the “vanguard of style” (p. 33), through practices such as playing MP3s, remixing music, and searching for fashion information. They interpreted this valuing of the Internet in relation to a more general and historical Trinidadian belief that style—including participating in international fashion—has profound value, as researched by Miller in the mid-1990s. Thus, an important meaning of comparative ethnography for the team involved interpreting current Internet practices in relation to the history of other Trinidadian cultural practices and meanings. Miller and Slater were critical of ethnographic projects that were ahistorical or that bracketed one form of social practice, such as Internet practice, from other aspects of social life: “In most ethnographic reportage of quality, the length and breadth of the study allows one topic to be understood as also an idiom for something else” (p. 22).

Miller and Slater (2000) used a house-to-house survey as a broad means of understanding the extent of the infusion of the Internet into Trinidadian life, conducting this survey within the same diverse housing districts that Miller (1994) used in his earlier research, chosen to represent a “very ordinary section” of the society as a whole, including residential areas, public housing, and a district of squatters (p. 196). The researchers argued that the house-to-house survey gave them a very different kind of information than they would have gleaned from means that are more formal and especially information concerning how Trinidadians often connect to the Internet in highly informal and

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In selecting work for the following review and analysis, I have focused on studies that seek to understand the relationships and connections among activity and social spaces that are decidedly Internet related and activity and social spaces that may appear distant from the Internet. In reviewing and selecting work, I have also sought to represent multiple ways in which such connections are conceived: while some studies concern the relations between the Internet and traditional media, others follow literacy practices in and out of school, while still others are concerned with tracing how student identities move across space-time. I have focused on ethnographic and interpretive work over quantitative analyses based on survey research, interview research, or other methods, although I realize that such work could be used to make claims about connections between online and offline practices. Finally, I have favored relatively detailed discussions of the relationships conceived and enacted within several key studies, rather than describing a broader range of work and abstracting principles or traversing themes.

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Building upon this earlier work, the following studies begin to more deliberately and self-consciously develop methodologies and findings that traverse offline and online social life in new ways. The following is a selective and not exclusive discussion of important methodological and empirical connective ethnographies of the Internet (see also Bennett, 2004; Kendall, 1999; Mann & Stewart, 2002; Sade-Beck, 2004). I have drawn from studies taking different forms, including two book-length treatments in the first cases and research articles in the others.

Daniel Miller and Don Slater

The Internet: An Ethnographic Approach reports on Daniel Miller and Don Slater's (2000) study of uses of the Internet and meanings of Internet culture

embedded in Trinidad as a place and related to the Trinidadian Diaspora. One of the key conclusions of the study is that Trinidadians have a seeming natural affinity for the Internet in its various manifestations. Miller and Slater did not assume a separation of the Internet from other aspects of daily life, and they argued to the contrary that, in Trinidad, there were very few places where commerce or e-commerce, chat on playgrounds or in ICQ, or religious instruction as carried out face-to-face or by e-mail were treated in terms of clear distinctions between the "real" and the "virtual" (p. 6). While some relationships, forms of commerce, and other activities may exist uniquely online, the key issue is that participants weave these social spaces and relations into their lives in such a way that the online is experienced as real and as common place and that transitions between online and offline social spaces and identities may be less marked than researchers assume.

Miller and Slater (2000) called their approach "comparative ethnography" (p. 9), and part of the key to understanding their methodology is to consider their own scholarly histories. Miller studied culture in Trinidad for over a decade, including work on business, consumption, kinship, and identity. In contrast, Slater's expertise was online environments and practices and especially forms of chat. The comparative ethnography proceeded by considering Miller's funds of knowledge of Trinidadian culture in relation to the examination of Internet culture and practice, guided by Slater. For example, the pair posited that in Trinidad, the Internet is associated with the "vanguard of style" (p. 33), through practices such as playing MP3s, remixing music, and searching for fashion information. They interpreted this valuing of the Internet in relation to a more general and historical Trinidadian belief that style—including participating in international fashion—has profound value, as researched by Miller in the mid-1990s. Thus, an important meaning of comparative ethnography for the team involved interpreting current Internet practices in relation to the history of other Trinidadian cultural practices and meanings. Miller and Slater were critical of ethnographic projects that were ahistorical or that bracketed one form of social practice, such as Internet practice, from other aspects of social life: "In most ethnographic reportage of quality, the length and breadth of the study allows one topic to be understood as also an idiom for something else" (p. 22).

Miller and Slater (2000) used a house-to-house survey as a broad means of understanding the extent of the infusion of the Internet into Trinidadian life, conducting this survey within the same diverse housing districts that Miller (1994) used in his earlier research, chosen to represent a "very ordinary section" of the society as a whole, including residential areas, public housing, and a district of squatters (p. 196). The researchers argued that the house-to-house survey gave them a very different kind of information than they would have gleaned from means that are more formal and especially information concerning how Trinidadians often connect to the Internet in highly informal and

resourceful ways. Data collection in the surveyed areas also included in-depth individual household interviews and informal inquiries in the four districts (p. 197).

Methodologically, long-standing relationships with Trinidadian families from Miller's earlier research were critically important to developing the project during their 5 intensive weeks of data collection while in Trinidad (Miller & Slater, 2000). Another meaning of *comparative* during data collection involved comparisons across multiple online and offline sites. During the key data collection period, the researchers often engaged in face-to-face interviews in the mornings around broader Internet-culture relations and then spent the afternoons and evenings "lyming" or hanging out in cybercafés, watching people go online or chatting with them online (p. 22). Following their work in Trinidad, the researchers collected Internet data for months following, remaining in touch with some informants for as long as 15 months through chat and e-mail. The pair also made use of their own embodied circulations to interview Trinidadians in London and New York.

In developing an approach to connective ethnography by drawing on insights from Miller and Slater (2000), the most important contribution of their comparative ethnography might be the analytic dimensions they developed for approaching comparative analysis. While the researchers recognized that these dimensions, as "dynamics," are gleaned from the case of Trinidad, they also invited others to take up these four dynamics and to develop them in relation to other ethnographic settings (p. 9). First, "dynamics of objectification" refers to how people recognize or realize themselves through a domain of material culture, including Internet practices and resources (p. 10). This dimension may be one of the most familiar to Internet researchers, as it involves considering how the Internet is used as a means of identification. Second, dynamics of mediation refers to how people make use of the various "features, potentials, and dangers" of the Internet as media (p. 10). With respect to this dimension, Miller and Slater argued that it is essential not to consider the Internet merely as a monolith but to tease out the particulars of the range of practices and media that become collected under the heading of "the Internet." Third, particularly interesting for cross-site analysis, Miller and Slater discussed dynamics of normative freedom, which describes how people engage freedom as it is opened up through Internet practices. The term *normative freedom* used here is intended to capture a paradox: Any notion of freedom also takes the form of a social order (p. 16). As such, at issue is not so much a grand conflict between freedom and constraint but, rather, the particulars of how different forms and discourses of social order come into contact (p. 18). A fourth and final dimension, dynamics of positioning, describes how people engage with networks that transcend their immediate locations, including the flows of cultural, political, and financial resources (p. 10). "Positioning is about strategies for surviving or succeeding in these new flows and spaces" (p. 20).

A fascinating example of drawing on one of these four dimensions for analysis involves Miller and Slater's (2000) discussion of how some Trinidadian teens attribute specific Internet practices to stages of development and identity. In this case, we see the dynamics of objectification traversing online and offline identities. For example, Trinidadian teens describe how a prepersonal Web site phase or pre-ICQ phase is followed by a phase of heavy involvement in cybersex and Internet porn and then a later phase in which Internet sex and pornographic activity is considered uncool. Along with these phases of activity come naming practices: While earlier and less-experienced adolescents might call one another by their ICQ nicknames, this practice is considered uncool by older adolescents (p. 76). The researcher's analysis suggested how other identity categories (e.g., adolescence, man, woman, lesbian, poor, or academic) might also be materially stitched together with particular Internet practices.

A further example of the potential comparative value of the dynamics for analysis, which especially draws out the dynamics of objectification and dynamics of positioning, involves how Trinidadians use Internet practices for the performance of national identity. Trinidadians enter and practice the network "as a people who [feel] themselves encountering it from a place" (Miller & Slater, 2000, p. 105). Despite the broad dispersal of the Trinidadian Diaspora, and despite the global commodification of culture, Trinidadians continually practice their national identities online and consume the Internet as a source of nationalism. For example, the home pages of Trinidadians are often replete with core nationalistic symbols, such as flags, crests, maps, and national statistics. Web pages, online chat, and news groups are also used to practice cultural identities through language play ("lyming"), Trini-style jokes, and even explanations for outsiders to help them learn about Trinidadian culture. Miller and Slater comparatively interpreted this nationalism and practice of cultural identity as related to a historical ethos of resistance to forces such as slavery and colonialism but at the same time as indexing the fragile state of Trinidad as a nation state (p. 115; British and American nationalism was also evident in Hine's, 2000, study, p. 114; see also Mitra, 1997). Instances of national identification practices as documented in ethnography run counter to the rhetoric of replacement or substitution (e.g., Castells, 1996), where global processes of identification somehow overtake forms of identification associated with nation-states and other places.

While Miller and Slater (2000) drew on a strong sense of place and situatedness to understand the Internet in Trinidad, an important relational principle of their larger project was to move beyond the dualism of the local and the global. They worked to build a perspective that did not abstract the global Internet from the local place of Trinidad and "Trininess" as cultural practice but, rather, considered the dialectics and circulations of the general and specific. The ethnography is not about how a global form "out there" is appropriated by a local social space that is set apart, but about "how Trinidadians put

themselves into this global arena and become part of a force that constitutes it, but do so quite specifically as Trinidadians" (p. 7).

Christine Hine

Hine's (2000) *Virtual Ethnography* is a rich and influential text for developing ethnographic approaches to researching complex connections among myriad social sites, both online and offline. The topic of Hine's ethnography reported in this text was the event around Louise Woodward, a teenage British nanny tried in Boston, in 1997, for the murder of a child for whom she had been caring. Hine's purpose was to use the events around Woodward as a way of thinking about the social construction of the Internet, a purpose that emerged when the judge for the trial announced that he would release his ruling on the case via the Internet. At the beginning of her study, Hine did not plan the types and forms of data she would collect, but rather, followed leads as the multimediated event around the Woodward case developed. She described a dizzying sense of excitement and engagement with an "ongoing and living event" (p. 71) in trying to capture Web sites that were dynamically developed to report on the case, temporally tracking changes in these Web sites and studying the incoming and outgoing links among them. Hine and an assistant also recorded and archived media reports on the Woodward case from television, radio, and print news media. Following the verdict on the case, Hine's data collection slowed and narrowed; she focused her Web site analysis to support sites for either side in the case, contacted site developers and carried out online interviews with them, and studied some newsgroup interactions around the case. Thus, Hine's connective or virtual ethnography of Internet practice involved data seemingly entirely collected online, and yet articulated these data with accounts from other news media about the case. Traditional news media function as offline data in unbounding the online from social practice.

While Hine's (2000) research and study offered many valuable insights for the development of connective ethnography, including a list of methodological principles (pp. 63–65), in the following, I highlight just a few key issues. The first of these, perhaps most characteristic and unique in Hine's approach, involves understanding the Internet as culture and cultural artifact. The culture/cultural artifact relation is not intended as a dichotomous approach but as an heuristic that captures how everyday Internet practices shape the Internet as a social object and how a broad range of reifications and representations of the Internet also socially shape it as being a particular kind of object. "Treating the Internet as a cultural artifact interrogates the assumptions which viewing the Internet as a site for culture entails, and highlights the status of the Internet as itself a cultural achievement based on particular understandings of the technology" (p. 39). Drawing on science and technology studies, as well as situated studies of other media use, Hine argued that the meaning of the Internet

is socially and culturally indeterminate, distributed across a wide and varied range of actors.

Hine (2000) saw events, such as the Louise Woodward case, as active in organizing and recruiting meaningful connections between Internet practices and Internet representations and circumstances of use or the Internet as a cultural artifact. She related the development of Internet-media accounts and discussions of the Woodward case to how television, radio, and print journalism concurrently reported the case and its relationship to the Internet. As with other analyses informed by science and technology studies, Hine's account is somewhat organized around technology trouble: Technical problems force the judge's announcement of his verdict to be delayed, a delay that other media outlets picked up on and used to cast the Internet in a negative light relative to their own superior timing and reliability. Most people learned first of the verdict through television or radio. Yet, even before the trial outcome, Hine documented how the newspapers and television news, who anticipated the Internet-mediated trial news, took on the task of explaining what the Internet was for and what was sensible to do with it, agreeing with or harshly critiquing the judge's decision to use the Internet. Television footage appeared to struggle to figure out how to represent the Internet as a location, showing people seated in front of computers and then zooming in on Web pages.

Less central to Hine's (2000) overall project, but nevertheless an important set of insights, were her analyses of the spatial and temporal dimensions of Internet practice as lived experience. Like others (e.g., Miller & Slater, 2000), Hine critiqued the technocentrism of Castells (1996), who celebrated the Internet-induced temporal collage and reconfiguration of social space. Hine, in contrast, traced how information and advocacy Web sites in the Louise Woodward trial became arranged as more or less central or marginal. Even while the Internet is hypertextually structured and potentially an entirely connected space, Web developers who she studied in the Woodward case had an intense awareness of the territoriality of their own Web sites or the "spatiality which stems from the differential connectedness of sites" (p. 105). This territory-construction by linking is of course also connected to the digital-material realities of Web server space that Web developers struggled for and were allocated. While the number of Web sites associated with the case grew very rapidly (from 165 to over 700 in a week), and some of these sites deemed themselves as official and authoritative, Hine analyzed how the official Louise Campaign for Justice Web site became the key site. The centrality of this site—its flow across the entire network—is analyzed by considering not only the number of hits to the site but also how the more peripheral and amateur sites repeatedly featured prominent links to it. Other circulation-related practices could include a broad range of ways of constructing extensibility and getting attention through media, including the practices of registering Web sites with search engines, paying for registration services, and even handing out business

cards with Web site addresses (Hine, 2000, p. 106). Importantly, Hine also argued that the offline physical location of the site was critical in constructing its centrality amidst the flow of interactions:

The official site was considered authoritative and up-to-date due to its proximity to the campaigners in Elton, and through them to Louise herself ... The connection between the offline location of the village and the online location of the website [*sic*] was strongly rendered. (p. 107)

Thus, Hine's research suggested that we carefully consider how flow is an achievement of sociomaterial networking among disparate resources, connecting the global and the local, material and symbolic centers and margins.

Nina Wakeford

Nina Wakeford's (1999) research was located differently from each of the first two projects in this section, both literally and figuratively. First, as her work was situated as a participatory ethnography within a cybercafé, it is a closely grounded ethnography in a more traditional sense. Second, Wakeford's work may be positioned as connective not by its substantive connections between offline and online activity but rather by how it focuses upon particular connective agents—human cyberhosts who translate the Internet as a certain kind of cultural experience. Wakeford analyzed the construction of Internet culture and practice at the intersections of material cybercafé spaces, online spaces, people with different investments (e.g., users, staff), performances of gender and power, and aesthetic, material culture. As Hine (2000) did, Wakeford offered an interpretation of the Internet as cultural practice and artifact and especially an analysis of the Internet as material culture (Miller & Slater, 2000). In spatial terms, Wakeford's work was highly suggestive for moving methodology toward a serious consideration of material, symbolic, imagined, and performed spaces in the social construction of the Internet.

Wakeford (1999) proposed that situated, material-technical networks of the Netcafé be conceived as the intersection of three landscapes of computing. While "online landscapes" concern the visual and textual practices on the machines, "expert landscapes of the machine" are practiced by technicians who set up networks, keep hardware and software running, and so forth (p. 189). "Translation landscapes" are those most directly linked to staff such as "cyberhosts" who produce and interpret the Internet for customers, translating Internet knowledge, practices, and culture (p. 189). Wakeford was primarily interested in the work of translation, conducting the ethnography, in part, by working as a cyberhost herself. In particular, Wakeford documented how the main café floor is performed as a site of the Internet with a strong sense of material and symbolic Internet presence, through the maintenance of a stylized cyber interior, by the situated reworking of London subcultures, including nightclub music and fashion, and by the roles of the cyberhosts—serving

coffee, snacks, and online time. Wakeford analyzed how a particular imagination of the Internet guided the ongoing construction of Netcafé by its managers and cyberhosts, a story where Internet access was not influenced by gender and where women were encouraged to identify with Internet practices.

A particular cultural imagination of the café and the Internet more broadly, as captured in brochures and main floor practices, however, conflicted with other imagined and practiced spaces. The front stage performance of the Internet on and with the main café floor hid backstage practices and spatial divisions. For example, while the second floor of the Netcafé provided office space for management, including the two women who pioneered the business, the top floor housed mostly men in a technical support area, which was avoided by the women cyberhosts as “stinky,” littered, and distasteful (p. 190). Wakeford (1999) recorded that the stairwell was an important physical space of negotiation among various staff members—a space where the translation landscape of computing was worked out and hidden from public view (p. 191). On the café floor, the Internet was also often gendered by customers, who tended to ask the women cyberhosts to serve coffee and the men for help with machine problems (p. 193).

Wakeford's (1999) work creatively problematizes the view of the Internet as any single object or practice—not simply because the Internet is composed of a myriad of technical tools but because it is culturally distributed across practices, including serving and drinking coffee, negotiating and bounding physical spaces, and consuming particular types of clothing and music. A second important methodological principle that can be gleaned from her work is to consider which human and nonhuman agents are active in serving up the Internet. While in studying Internet practice, it is easy to lose sight of human and nonhuman mediators or Internet servers, Wakeford reminds us to consider an understanding of these servers and their everyday work in translating the Internet in practice.

Sarah Holloway and Gil Valentine

The work of Sarah Holloway, Gil Valentine, and colleagues (Holloway, Valentine, & Bingham, 2000; Holloway & Valentine, 2001) in the United Kingdom was somewhat similar in its approach to Wakeford's (1999) work in that it was more concerned with the situation and framing of Internet-related practice than with making connections among particular online and offline social practices. Like the work of Wakeford and others, the research also provided an important argument for taking a socially dynamic and connective approach to practice rather than bracketing social spaces such as home, school, online, and offline in advance. As an illustration, the researchers reconceived the problem of information and communication technology (ICT) access as a problem of identification. Across home and different school settings, Holloway and Valentine (2001) documented practices of identification with technology by youth,

including how they negotiate their technical competence to be more or less visible. Technology emerged as a signifier of social inadequacy for some boys in school, who risked being labeled “geeks” or “homos,” while skills in particular computer games, which were acquired at home, carried cultural capital into the school setting. Moreover, while some girls received praise from parents for technical competency at home, they strategically used technical practices sparingly at school to “win social popularity as well as the grudging respect of their peers for their technical skill” (p. 36). Rather than documenting a stable set of meanings and practices within contexts, this research traces a complex, dynamically shifting articulation of techno-literacy practices, social spaces, and identity.

In another study (Valentine, Holloway, & Bingham, 2002), the work aligned with Hine’s (2000) call to analyze the Internet as a cultural artifact by analyzing how three different schools discursively constituted the Internet as a very different kind of object. These three discourses on Internet technologies included “ICT for all,” which included access for the wider community, “ICT as a life skill,” and “ICT in terms of academic achievement” (p. 312). These discourses helped to structure different types of access and surveillance of ICT practices not only within, but also outside of school. Holloway and Valentine (2001) also documented how discourses of the “child in danger” and “the dangerous child” (Oswell, 1998) are appropriated and sometimes resisted by parents and schools in efforts to regulate Internet content. Relations to these discourses suggest how identities of “the child” and “the adolescent” are produced in relationship to computers and other nonhuman actors. For critical literacy studies, in particular, this work points to the need engage in discourse analysis of a range of texts (e.g., interviews, texts from online and offline interactions, popular media, and policy documents) to understand how the Internet continues to be produced and consumed in different ways for and by different groups of people.

Recent and Current Connective Ethnographies of the Digital Literacies of Youth

In the summer of 2005, a multidisciplinary Conference on Digital Cultures and Place was held in Taiwan, sponsored by the Taipei Institute of Ethnology and Academia. The purpose of the conference was to situate emerging digital cultures in the context of both local cultural traditions and globalization (http://home.actlab.utexas.edu/pipermail/discuss/2005_February/000049.html), including adaptations of local art forms to digital media, local conceptions of the global community, and concepts of the body and language emerging in Asian digital genres. The realization of this event, the discourse of which would have astounded scholars just 5 years ago, is indicative of how quickly diverse fields are moving toward interpreting digital practices in relation to global/local dynamisms.

This area of work is in constant flux and development; even as I write this chapter, a major new, multisited ethnography has just been funded. “Kids’ Informal Learning with Digital Media,” under the direction of Peter Lyman at UC Berkeley and Mimi Ito at the University of Southern California, will involve diverse youth ages 10 to 18 in 4 physical sites and up to 20 virtual spaces (<http://groups.sims.berkeley.edu/digitalyouth/>). One of the pressing concerns of literacy researchers will be to recognize and collaborate with much of the work of relevance to literacy research and theory that is happening outside of language and literacy departments and colleges of education, including the Lyman and Ito study, as well as some of the work discussed in this section.

Four recent or current ethnographic projects are described in some detail in this section. I have chosen instead to focus on a small handful of studies that vary in terms of scale, purpose, and geographic location. I have selected projects that take an explicit connective stance to their work—examining relations and understandings across settings, across online and offline practices, and across new Internet practices and media with longer histories. I have also tried to describe ethnographic research that is not well represented elsewhere in this volume, including the chapters by Gloria Jacobs and Angela Thomas. The following discussions of the studies, based upon interviews with the researchers or self-reporting in the case of my own work, move from general questions and histories behind the different inquiries, to issues of methodological design, to considering the differences that a connective approach makes. Finally, for each study I consider particular ethical issues. Rather than separating out a discussion of general ethical issues involved in connective ethnography, I have chosen to embed the discussions of ethical dilemmas and partial resolutions within the particulars of each study.

Eva Lam: Electronic Literacy and Global English in the Lives of Immigrant Youth in the United States

Eva Lam is developing a program of research investigating how immigrant youth in the United States use digital literacy practices, and the relationships of these practices to their English learning, social networks, and identities. Lam’s work is pushing beyond a learning perspective informed by acculturation, prevalent in ESL literature, and moving rather toward a perspective informed by transculturation. She traced how immigrant youth engage in multiple forms of cultural belonging, including online communities that traverse national boundaries and that, hence, cannot be described by a nation-centered discourse or methodology. The history of Lam’s involvement in online work is particularly interesting with respect to connections across online and offline practices. Lam’s intent was not originally to study online practices, but more broadly, literacy practices she deemed cross-cultural, such as reading and writing comics (personal communication, June 5, 2005). She became fascinated, however, with one student who blossomed online through activities

like developing his own Web site about Japanese pop culture. This student's confidence with English and perspective on his own social future convinced Lam to further examine the digital literacies of immigrant youth.

Following this early study, Lam next developed four case studies of Chinese immigrant youth and their school-based and online literacies, which is the key study I discuss (Lam 2004). As Lam moved into this work, she became particularly motivated to understand how the *de facto* segregation of immigrant groups in school, and the social disparagement of the accented speech of English Language Learners, was considerably challenged by the unique social spaces and practices of the Internet. For example, code mixing between English and Romanized Cantonese in the "Hong Kong Chat Room" was considered normative for some students online and was used to index social alignments and cultural assumptions, while such mixing or social alignments were absent in the school context. In the next phase of Lam's work, which began in spring 2005, she planned to study 30 immigrant students over the course of 1 year, with a possible follow-up of a 2nd year (personal communication, June 5, 2005). One of Lam's key goals in this new work, besides scaling up the research, was to trace language development and modes of participation longitudinally.

Lam used a number of common means of naturalistic data collection over 8 months, including survey, participatory research, participant observation in school settings, textual documentation, and extensive field noting and documentation of online and offline activities. She regularly browsed and recorded versions of the anime Web page that one of her participants was developing. To record online activity, Lam used screen-capture software developed by ACD Systems. Home visits in the research were somewhat limited and were directed primarily toward understanding the daily lives of the students and their family cultures and how materials and practices were arranged on their computers. Most observations of online activity occurred during after school hours in the school computer lab. Through the course of her study, Lam realized the multiple classroom visits to different types of classes in school became redundant—not providing much new information—and she began to make more frequent use of student focus groups to understand general ideas and patterns that cut across online and offline engagements. Lam found that this process of scaling up her research at different points and levels was a helpful complement to the in-depth case studies she was developing. Lam described her work on data analysis as "cross-sectional," that is, comparatively interpreting patterns of practice and social networks across online and offline contexts of the students' lives.

Lam (personal communication, June 5, 2005) raised a key issue in transitioning from a text-based approach, as informed by early work in computer mediated communication, to a more richly social approach to online ethnography: "Am I approaching this as text—that the students produce, or am I

approaching it as a social community and really thinking about the people that are involved—the other participants” (personal communication, June 5, 2005)? To develop a social approach, building connections across online and offline contexts was essential to her research questions, questions which were informed by the students’ accounts of how they translated their experiences across offline and online contexts.

I saw the connection in how their local situation predisposed them, in a way, in their approach to online practices, and how these online practices in turn effected their views of themselves in the local situation—in the school, and in the community. If I had not discovered this from them, I’m not so sure that I would be so eager to look at cross-contextual ways that people participate. I really discovered this from them. (personal communication, June 5, 2005)

One significant instance of the predisposition to certain forms of online practices is the immigrant students’ use of English online, while they certainly had many linguistic and cultural communities available to them. Lam interpreted this use in the global medium of the Internet in relation to the students’ local situations and life goals that she gleaned information from in her offline research: “The way I analyze and interpret their [online] practices were very much dependent upon my understanding of the school and their lives in the U.S.” (personal communication, June 5, 2005).

A key ethical issue that Lam considered as her research developed concerns the extent to which the interactions of interlocutors, who are not focal participants, may be considered as data. Lam recorded only dialogues in the public forums of chat rooms, but she did not have consent from all participants in such chat rooms. What is the nature of these interactions? What, further, is the status of materials such as e-mails that focal research participants receive from others? Why is it that a person in offline research might share a letter with a researcher but permission would be needed to share an e-mail? One ethical compromise that Lam reached for related issues was that she used general perspectives from participants about particular forums (e.g., a chat room) and their social dynamics without official consent but did not use their personal information or personal communications. Lam also raised the important ethical question of the nature of giving and obtaining consent online, particularly in the case of minors: How valid is online consent, and how do we verify online identities?

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Rodney Jones: Computer Mediated Communication and Youth Literacy in Hong Kong: A Participatory Ethnographic Approach

In 2005 Rodney Jones and Co-PI David Li ended a 2-year, funded study in Hong Kong on the communication and literacy practices of 40 youth, in and out of school. One of Jones' motivations for engaging in the study was to understand why Hong Kong schools seemed so "out of synch" (personal communication, May 30, 2005) with the wired culture of Hong Kong outside of schools. Jones noted that many school practices were "like being back in the 19th Century" (personal communication, May 30, 2005). Broadly, Jones also wanted to give youth an opportunity to reflect on what they were doing online and share their online knowledge and practices with teachers and parents. As Jones analyzed and reported from his data, he became increasingly interested in broader issues, such as the relationships of online and offline practices to time and space.

As in the case of Lam, Jones' "recruitment" into analyzing offline/online connections is fascinating. As an applied linguist, Jones was interested in IMing a few years ago and began to amass an impressive collection of IM transcripts from his university students; however, Jones eventually found that reading these transcripts as data was unsatisfying and even boring:

I could make statements about patterns of language use, but I didn't find making those statements to be particularly useful, because they're patterns of language use that are taken out of the context of social interaction, and so, I thought, I really have to get at this in a more physical way. (personal communication, May 30, 2005)

After this experience, Jones designed a pilot study to develop a participatory methodology, in which he recruited 6 university students to research their own online practices with him. The key methodological issue in this pilot project and in his current work, in Jones' view, is the nature of the relationships between the researcher and the participants; he sees it as essential to disrupt the binary and power relationship of researcher/research subject in order to get at more native ways of understanding the meaning of digital practices.

In his current, large-scale project with youth aged 14 to 18 years, Jones' design of participatory methodology has evolved and scaled up to enroll university students who function as "big brothers" and "big sisters" to the youth whose practices they are attempting to understand (personal communication, May 30, 2005). These 1st- and 2nd-year university students engaged in peer to peer observation in home settings, helped with school-based data collection, conducted interviews, managed screen captures of online practices

(using Spector software), and were involved in other forms of data collection for their respective groups of 4 to 5 youth over 6 months of intensive data collection. Follow-up data collection occurred over nearly 2 years; however, administering data collection was less important to Jones than developing relationships with the youth as slightly older friends:

What's more important for me is that they just kind of hang out with them. I think that quite a lot of what I'm trying to get at, may not be able to be gotten at by just looking at what they're doing when they're sitting around computers. (personal communication, May 30, 2005)

"Hanging out" in the research involved going out to shopping centers, going out to eat, and generally engaging as participant observers with the youth in a large range of offline and online situations. Another innovative way in which Jones and colleagues structured a participatory form of research involves data analysis (personal communication, May 30, 2005). In the summer of 2005, the team hired some secondary student researchers to help in data analysis, follow-up interviewing, data archiving, and other aspects of the project. Jones' belief was that these more native informants would bring substantial value to the analysis phase of the work as well.

Data collection in the classroom part of this research proceeded along mostly traditional ethnographic lines, including collecting written work, observing, videotaping classroom interactions, and interviewing teachers and parents. Besides direct observation of online practices and screen capturing, three additional innovative means of collecting data deserve mention. First, the youth in the study developed Web sites on which they reported their results and insights from their self-study to teachers and others and held public presentations to present their findings. (In personal communication, May 30, 2005, Jones reported an important and surprising revelation on how their participating youth lied to their parents and teachers about their everyday online digital literacy practices.) Second, like Hine (2000), Jones was purposefully involved in collecting media reports such as newspaper articles and television segments on the online practices of youth in Hong Kong as part of his data set. In general, this media discourse is against any forms of nonschool related practices and creates a discourse of Internet danger and contagion concerning the Internet's relationship to sex and crime. Jones saw the media reports and their discourse as socially shaping how the Internet is used and how youth practices are monitored in and out of school. Third, in order to get at something of the complex set of events that are going on in the material world while kids are interacting online, including the fact that many interactions happen as social events among friends, Jones began to experiment with collecting data via Webcams that can record something of the "event complex" around the computer. He noted that managing this data collection along with other forms of screen capturing and collection is difficult.

The event complex is just one instance and example of the importance of gathering and interpreting data from multiple sites. The following passage from my interview with Jones (personal communication, May 30, 2005) is quoted at length as a robust description of the need for online/offline flow in ethnography:

The difference is that if you just took either [online or offline] side of it, you wouldn't understand what's going on. For instance, you can't hang out with these kids, in the physical world, without having some understanding of what they're doing online, because you wouldn't understand their relationships, you wouldn't understand a lot of the things that they say even because they are contingent upon things that they say online, or certain expressions that develop online and seep into the normal conversation in the physical world. So, not knowing what they're doing online, you'd be pretty much in the same position that their parents are in (laughs). They'd have a lot of secrets from you. At the same time, just looking at what they're doing online—for me this is a really important point—I think would completely miss the point of studying online behavior. Because it would set up this kind of idea that what they do online is somehow separate from what they do offline, that there's this kind of "cyberspace," where they go and do all sorts of these special things, and there's a clear boundary that's drawn, and, that's not what's happening at all. What they're doing online has a lot to do with what they're doing in the real world.

As an everyday example of these traversals, Jones noted how youth routinely remarked that they would not have their particular set of offline friends without the opportunities to meet and develop relationships online.

For data analysis in such a large-scale project, Jones described his central challenge as organizing the data such that a "polychronic orientation" (personal communication, May 30, 2005) can develop around the multiple engagements of any one participant in one particular period. Jones wanted to understand how school assignments, online gaming, life happenings, friendships, romances, and other areas of youth lives are interconnected or bounded at particular moments. "Over the course of six months of someone's life, everything is connected, in one way or another, and so the trick is trying to be able to trace those connections" (personal communication, May 30, 2005). In data collection and analysis, he saw a connective, relational perspective as essential to his project (personal communication, May 30, 2005). Jones and colleagues were using Atlas, a qualitative archiving and analysis tool, to organize, analyze, and search through their data.

Jones (personal communication, May 30, 2005) noted two key ethical issues in his research, the first of which was also discussed by Lam (personal communication, June 5, 2005): How should screen captures of participants'

online activity be handled when such data also include the communications of many who have not given informed consent (personal communication, May 30, 2005)? A general approach that Jones and colleagues took to mitigate this dilemma at the outset of the study was to have participants send a message to all of the people on their buddy lists, noting that they were in the study and would sometimes be recorded when interacting. Jones noted, however, that the problem of not being able to control who will “stumble into” (personal communication, May 30, 2005) an online study is still something he did not solve. Another ethical issue in the study concerned one of the participants who was a gay youth and was involved in a number of forms of online activity that may well have concerned his parents had they been aware of them. In the case of this boy, what he was doing and the identity he was projecting online was quite distinct from his offline life in his family; Jones described the boy as engaging in forms of activity that were a likely “rehearsal” (personal communication, May 30, 2005) for activity in the future.

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Brian Wilson: Youth Culture, Global Flows, and Political Activism

On the one hand, Brian Wilson’s work was less directly related to literacy than some of the other research discussed in this section, while on the other hand, his work is highly related to a number of research directions concerning literacy, social justice, and youth culture. Wilson was concerned with how media of different types—and in particular Web sites and related online media—are used by youth in different forms of political activism. Wilson’s approach to looking across online and offline contexts to understand youth culture developed in part through an earlier ethnography (1995–1998) in which he examined the rave subculture in Southern Ontario, Canada (personal communication, June 7, 2005). The cultural practices of the ravers studied by Wilson included organizing local raves, or all-night dance parties, but also connecting with other ravers around the world online and sharing music. As with other work discussed previously, including Lam’s research, Wilson did not set out originally to examine Internet-related practices; rather, he got “pulled into” them after it was clear that the Internet was a “central meeting place, a space of organization, and a cultural reference point for young ravers” (personal communication, June 7, 2005).

Wilson’s second major study was an analysis of activist youth organizations/networks and how these networks are tapping into the potential of the Internet to further their causes and voices (personal communication, June 7, 2005).

While the Internet has been recognized as a venue for a broad range of activist causes among adults (e.g., Downing, 2000; Withford, 2000), little work has been done in media studies, and perhaps less in literacy studies, concerning how youth also organize forms of social critique and activism through online venues. Wilson critiqued how youth have been infantilized and apoliticized by the popular media and previous research. Youth, for instance, are depicted to express themselves and their dissatisfaction or resistance around symbolic means and style (e.g., hair or clothing styles) but not around direct forms of social activism. Wilson sought to examine the relationships between online and offline forms of activism for youth (approximately ages 13 to 25), how local and global activist communities are formed, and related issues that will flesh out part of the picture on the "culture of activism" (personal communication, June 7, 2005).

The design of Wilson's ethnography of youth activism comprises three phases (personal communication, June 7, 2005). The first phase consisted of identifying seven, youth-driven networks/organizations concerned with different social issues, including racial conflict, native youth issues, globalization, genetic engineering, and war, and studying the content of the Web sites of these organizations. Wilson saw the textual or content analysis of Web sites, and other online media, as an important method in the media studies tradition that was somewhat lost in early (e.g., mid- to late 1990s) research of Internet activity that assumed a treatment of the Internet as a world apart. He also noted that traditional content analysis is justified in part by the fact that the Internet is itself saturated with mainstream media (e.g., CNN, MTV). In phase two of his study, Wilson and his research team conducted interviews with the producers of the organizations' Web sites as well as with movement organizers and participants. The purpose of this phase was to move from textual analysis to issues of situated production and consumption.

Phase three of Wilson's new research, which had not yet begun at time of writing, moves entirely offline, in that the plan is to observe and interview participants at informal events organized by these groups, including rallies and protests (personal communication, June 7, 2005). Particularly noteworthy from a connective standpoint is that Wilson wanted to understand how online communications and texts become embedded, interpreted, and realized in offline social action. His hope was to understand what social activists interpret as successful activity for them, which may include attendance at offline events, participation in and support of online forums, or mainstream media uptake of offline events. This latter issue is somewhat related to Hine's (2000) notion of considering the Internet as not just practice, but cultural artifact as well. Wilson was not so concerned, however, with how the Internet is represented in mainstream media, but rather with how, and if, social activism circulates into the mainstream media and is promoted by it. In simplistic terms, how might a handful of youth who have created a Web site and organized a

meeting around a social cause create a buzz on national television in Canada? Such analyses are clearly important for work in new literacy studies and its concerns with tracing how literacies are related to social futures and social action (Gee, Hull, & Lankshear, 1996; New London Group, 1996).

Wilson (personal communication, June 7, 2005) described the movements of people, information, money, and media in terms of flows and circuits; his thinking in this regard has been strongly influenced by the work of postcolonial theorist Appadurai (1996). Appadurai's conception of the relationship between flows of media ("technoscapes") and other flows (e.g., "ethnoscapes" or flows of people, and "financoscapes," or flows of money) nicely encapsulated a key question that Wilson arrived at regarding his own research agenda: "Am I studying the Internet as a new media, or am I a media studies person who is studying the movement of culture" (personal communication, June 7, 2005)? Wilson increasingly realized that the culture is his starting point rather than the Internet *per se* and that cultural flows, organizations, and practices cannot be well understood apart from the Internet:

For me, if I'm interested in studying the culture of a group, particularly youth, then I'm interested in their perspectives, identities, relationships, commitments, all those kinds of things. If I want to do a responsible job on that, then I'm going to be studying the Internet, because that's part of their everyday lives, and by virtue of that being part of their everyday lives, it now connects us not only to local cultures, but also to global cultures. (personal communication, June 7, 2005)

Wilson asserted that a connective stance and methodology is particularly important in studying forms of youth culture, because unlike previous generations (including perhaps many academics) for "most young people, offline and online are just not that distinct" (personal communication, June 7, 2005). From his study of rave culture, Wilson reflected how incomplete his interpretation would have been had he bracketed his research to offline activity:

You could study [rave culture] without actually looking at the Internet, but you wouldn't be able to get much insight into how it is that these young people actually organize themselves, you would only get part of the sense of how it is that rave is actually a community ... these are people who are communicating all week long without actually seeing each other. (personal communication, June 7, 2005)

Some of the ethical issues that Wilson and colleagues considered in their recent work are more directly related to the culture of activism rather than to challenges with Internet-related research *per se* (personal communication, June 7, 2005). Some of the activist groups that Wilson has studied have strong opinions about how the research project might be helpful to their own causes, and Wilson considered what forms of participatory involve-

ment this project or future projects might take, perhaps including directly supporting social activism, as seen in some action research. In this relation, social activist groups pose interesting questions related to masking the identity of research participants. While some of the groups would like to remain anonymous in the research, others might desire to use the visibility of the research process as another media to keep their causes in circulation. At the same time, groups are not homogeneous, and some individuals speaking within groups, even if they want these groups to be publicly known, might want to mask their own identities for various reasons. In his earlier research on raves, Wilson noted the ethical dilemma of using data from public newsgroups (personal communication, June 7, 2005). His approach to this problem was to write a short note to the newsgroup and inform them of his identity and research activity, and to invite those interested to seek more information within a second posting. Despite this process, Wilson was still uncertain about using newsgroup postings, noting that the discussion of how public such postings are and what assumptions members have regarding their postings are ongoing debates among Internet researchers.

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Kevin Leander: Studying Youth Networks across Space-Time

In the 2002–2003 academic year, I initiated a research project to study the literacy practices of youth in online and offline contexts. The project was named "Synchrony," an acronym signifying "Studying Youth Networks Across Time-Space." My initial aims in the project, as stated in an application to the Spencer Foundation, which funded the project with a Small Grant, were to enhance current understandings of (a) the use of digital literacy practices for identity and social networks, (b) literacy in relation to space-time, and (c) reflexively, new methodologies for conducting research across online and offline contexts. In retrospect, the theoretical goal of understanding literacy in relation to space-time was my greatest motivation. Prior to this study, I was

primarily researching face-to-face interactions in school-related situations and was developing ways to understand how talk, bodies, and materials are coordinated in interactions and how interactions might be interpreted in relation to space and time. In this way, the Synchrony project afforded a different venue for exploring enduring questions I had studied in other ways.

As I designed the study, I became aware that one of the schools we might be able to research in was a private, all girls school that had, in the past few years, become entirely wireless. The students carried laptops to all of their classes and home with them at night. I began to design into the study a contrast between this school and a public school that was closer to what I considered as typical for schooling in this period, which housed a little-used computer lab with Internet access. As such, early on in the study, contrasts seemed to be running in different directions: online/offline, in school/at home, and high tech/low tech. The design of the study involved, first, a period of identifying and recruiting key informants through surveying, screening interviews, and meetings in homes with parents. The recruitment period was slow and challenging, particularly with the private school situation; parents and students were not enthusiastic about opening up their online practices to researchers. The human subjects (IRB) process was also lengthy and challenging, in part due to the lack of knowledge about online practices in IRB review, as well as the ethical complexities of researching youth in public and private contexts. Eventually, after a slow start up, 8 participants were recruited and gave consent. Eventually, 7 youth participated as “full” key informants, while 1 was a partial informant.

Two graduate research assistants collaborated with me on the study and were responsible for collecting data in most of the biweekly—and later, weekly—home visits over 5 key months of data collection. Follow-up data collection with 2 key participants continued for an additional year and a half. One of the main reasons that the assistants were responsible for most of the home-based data collection was that we had negotiated with the IRB an agreement that researchers of the same gender as the participants would conduct home visits, and 7 of our 8 key participants were female. Home-visit data collection included participant observation of online activity and relevant offline activity, field noting, think-aloud interviewing during activity and postactivity, and using Spector, an online recording program, to capture screen shots, key strokes, IMing, and Web site movement. We worked on developing friendships with the key participants and were quite successful in some cases, although less so in others. With 1 youth, a male who was deeply into gaming, I eventually also began to videotape his interactions online as well as capture them with Spector, as I found that the games he was involved with moved too fast for Spector to capture them effectively. While the screen recording with video is not of high quality, and has the added problem of running at a different frame rate than the computer monitor, producing a horizontal band that moves up

the screen, these digital video recordings became a valuable source of visual and auditory data of online and offline activity.

The research in English and social studies classrooms was conducted through routine ethnographic means, including weekly participant observation, recording of field notes, a limited amount of audio recording of discussions, interviews with students on texts they had produced, collecting student work, and interviews with nonfocal students, teachers, and administrators. Another predictable challenge of the study design involved trying to scale up to multisite research with a small team of researchers. Even the study of 7 to 8 key participants became very large when multiplied by two classroom visits per week, home visits, managing digital data capture, interview schedules, photocopying coursework, consent processes, and so forth. Somewhat ironically, my own desire to study literacy and space-time in the study created a set of difficult space-time research challenges, making it more evident why educational ethnography is typically located in the classroom and does not move far from it.

One of the challenges I have found in connective ethnography analysis involves developing a set of constructs that does not label data according to location in a priori ways. That is, labeling practices “school-based” or “home-based” is contrary to my research purposes, if I am attempting to understand how practices bound or unbound social spaces. One imperfect compromise we have settled on thus far involves using the terms *school-selected* and *self-selected*, which highlights not location but the relationship of goals to the subject.

For many of our participants, social networks were partially contiguous across the online and offline, and our data made evident how certain students who were bounded in school settings, and especially special education students, were equally bounded from the mainstream in online, after school practices. Often, practices such as IMing and blogging were supportive of social relationships that were evident in face-to-face observations; however, particular social relationships and especially relationships that we came to see as “transitional” were often supported nearly entirely online. For instance, one of our participants frequently communicated with ninth graders through IMing, as she anticipated moving to the high school the following year. Other participants communicated with childhood or camp friends that they had moved away from or rarely saw. The male participant, who was involved in gaming, frequently communicated with gaming friends from Finland. The nature of the transition in this latter case was what Jones noted as a “rehearsal,” in that late in the summer of 2005, he was leaving for a year of studying abroad in Finland (personal communication, May 30, 2005).

Analytically, it has become particularly helpful in the Synchrony study to be able to compare a highly wired school with one that has much less access to technology. While we might imagine that this contrast would highlight

all of the unique possibilities of the wired school, on the contrary, we have become more aware of the unexpected connections between practices in the two schools, regardless of their technical differences. By juxtaposing these schools, and playing them off of the connections to self-selected digital practices, in and out of school, we have begun to be able to build some understanding of common ways in which space-time is “schooled.” A constant analytical challenge, related to the challenge of language use described previously, is to avoid technological and contextual determinisms and to understand how certain dimensions of social practice get reproduced or transformed.

In the Synchrony study, we have wrestled with some of the ethical issues described by others in this section, including the use of data captured incidentally in online interactions. One way that we have addressed the issue of “incidental data” from the participant’s perspective is to allow our research participants to review Spector files before turning them over to us and to delete anything they would not like to share as data. Another issue mentioned previously was how to secure consent from online contacts, and, in the case of minors, from their parents as well. A complexity of this issue is whether the model of the face-to-face consent process actually ensures more or less protection for contacts and friends known only online. In our project, we have taken the position that online contacts are sometimes more protected by not collecting additional information from them that would be required in the process, including names, signatures, and home addresses for mailing forms. Rather, we have set up a more informal Web-based consent where the person can grant nonlegal consent through a Web form. We do not have any way of knowing whether the persons giving consent online are minors or not, but in this sense, the process partially mirrors the online knowledge of the participant. In terms of contacts that our participants also know face-to-face, we have used traditional consent measures.

This being said, however, while we wanted to enroll a large number of additional participants in the study as it moved along, including friends of the key informants so that we could begin to study social networks in a more robust way, we have not moved far in this direction. In many cases, we have one-sided authorized data in interactions. In the study, we came to see this as an important ethical issue in that in establishing trust and friendships with our participants we did not want them to feel that many of their social relationships were under the pressure of the research. We continue to consider this issue and think that possibly through longer term relationships and an increased emphasis on participatory ethnography we could expand laterally across the networks.

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Toward a Connective Ethnography: Future Directions and Possible Resources

In researching online literacies, how do we move from "roots to routes," as the formulation goes—how do we trace and map the texts and contexts articulated in the space-times of literacy practice? How do we reimagine and study the event, the text, the classroom, the school and global relations as a nexus—a "field of relations" (Olwig & Hastrup, 1997)—rather than as a container? If the Internet is not a single thing, but a heterogeneous assemblage of practices, texts, and cultures, then how are online territories performed through semiotic practices (Dodge & Kitchin, 2001)? Further, what form does ethnography take when it is no longer necessarily about physically displacing oneself, but about experiential displacement, a process of following connections?

If literacy research is to build on the connective approach informed by Miller and Slater (2000), Hine (2000), and others, one area of work that could lead in productive directions is actor network theory (ANT), historically associated with science and technology studies. In fact, part of what is striking in both Miller and Slater and Hine is more or less implicit critiques of the work of Castells (1996), with responses to these critiques offered by ANT, and especially the work of Latour (1987, 1988a). Separations of the real and the virtual, and the Internet and the self in Castells (1996) are problematized as dualisms that are overcome through the analysis of circulations and translations as described in ANT. From this vantage point, Miller and Slater conceived of the Internet and of what it meant to feel Trinidadian, as a conclusion rather than a starting point—as an effect of networking as a process.

In Latour's (1987, 1988a) work, space and time are less important than "spacing" and "timing" are (Bingham & Thrift, 2000). Uniquely Latourian is the way in which objects of all sorts—actants—are brought into circulation, including people but also, in his analysis of Einstein's work, trains, clouds, men with rigid rods, lifts, marble tables, molluscs, clocks, and rulers (Latour, 1988a). The material world is given its due; ANT offers a strong critique of transcendent notions of social life and power (e.g., micro- and macrorelations) and pushes rather to the analysis of the movements, alignments, and translations of everyday things, people, and texts. Historically, Latour (1988b) has had a keen interest in the function of texts in scientific and technical work, and the manner in which texts are immutable, or fix particular facts and forms of knowledge, and yet at the same time are mobile and combinable. Literacy

and texts, then, have a pivotal role in knowledge making and in translating the interests of other circulating actants. Use of ANT to conceptualize literacy practices and flows is work that is just beginning (e.g., Brandt & Clinton, 2002; Clarke, 2002; Leander & Lovvorn, 2006) and could be a highly promising resource for the development of connective ethnographic methodologies.

To study circulations—to move researcher bodies to trace traversals at spatial scales beyond the school yard—however, will require teams of researchers and/or novel solutions such as Jones' "big brother" approach described previously (personal communication, May 30, 2005). Jay Lemke (2000), revoicing Hillary Clinton, reminded us that it "takes a village" to study a village. Our current methodologies and studies are not realizations of ideal conceptual models, but rather pragmatic solutions to inquiry that are constrained by location, physical energy, the limits of attention, money, and ready-to-hand resources. Classroom-based research, or research bracketed to a single online Web source, does not happen incidentally, but rather, it is supported by the blocked and cut networks of academic life, isolated bodies, and an individualistic research culture.

While much of this chapter has emphasized connections, part of the promise of a developing connective ethnography will be to map how separations are produced as social achievements. Rather than presuming separations between school and out-of-school literacy practices, for example, such separations can be considered empirically, as forms of identity building, or producing communities, social groups, and institutions. As with connective work that has documented how spatially dispersed people create forms of nationalistic identification online (Miller & Slater, 2000), other forms of separation and identification, as mediated by texts and literacy practices will become evident empirically. Lam's (2004) work pointed to how the hybrid language practices of Romanized Cantonese, associated with a chat room, functions as a community and language-building social space that is somewhat unique and bracketed from other social spaces, but that this bracketing is producing a space of possibility over and against forms of segregation and isolation in school. In my own research, I have begun to document a social-spatial overlay between online social networks, the positions of student bodies in the school building, and the positions of these students' homes in their respective neighborhoods. Being in or out of the network may be reproduced along laminated social spaces.

Another key area of study regarding separations and boundary-making practices in online/offline networks regards how public and private texts and subjectivities are being coconstituted. Jones commented from his work in Hong Kong that young people were talking about "very private things" in online diaries and weblogs, yet posting these "private" messages on the World Wide Web at the same time (personal communication, May 30, 2005). Within this social practice, however, it seems clear that some texts are not intended for a public (e.g., parents), but by certain kinds of friends, as well as certain

others reading from certain positions. Jones gave the example of how a poem, written by a girl about breaking up with her boyfriend, could be read by the boyfriend, but also by other friends, who could comment on the boyfriend and on the relationship. We have recorded very similar kinds of interactions, which appear to operate at multiple levels and with different forms of address (Ellsworth, 1997), in the Synchrony study.

Closely related to both circulation and bounding practices, another important area of development, particularly for literacy studies, is to continue to consider how the Internet is reified through various texts and discourses—to trace not only traveling practices, but also how the Internet is objectified as a cultural artifact (Hine, 2000). Drawing on Pauly (1991), Jones (1999) discussed the closely related notion of “commentary,” which might include how we talk about the Internet as a realization of the “global village,” how we make claims about “Internet addiction,” the metaphor of the “information superhighway,” and so forth (p. 15). Jones reminded us that this commentary is not merely something to study that is outside of the researcher, but something that informs the researcher’s work as well. Critical discourse analysis (Fairclough, 1995; Gee, 1999), which has been so central to the development of the new literacy studies, could continue to be a highly important resource for examining digital practices, but understanding the Internet as a malleable social object demands an analysis of discourses on technology and not just discursive production through technology. In other terms, we may well need to turn our focus partially from the texts that youth are producing on the Internet to read these texts in relationship to the Internet, or to particular Internet practices, as a discursively constituted object. An even greater challenge will be to articulate this type of critical discursive work with the mapping of circulations, over and against assumptions about presumed micro- and macrorelations. In Hine’s (2000) imagination, “We could design ethnographic studies to track the ways in which conceptions of the Internet user were embedded into particular access points, advertisements, or pieces of hardware” (p. 35). Hine argues persuasively that we should take an ambivalent stance regarding appropriate sites to study for examining the cultural/discursive production and consumption of the Internet. Many of these sites will surely be offline, including film, print texts of all sorts, fashion, television, school computer labs (as texts), and, reflexively, the means and metaphors researchers use to describe online literacy practices.

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